PRESS INFORMATION BUREAU
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

COUNTRY WILL EMERGE STRONGER FROM CURRENT CRISIS

PRIME MINISTER WARNS AGAINST DESPONDENCY AND FRUSTRATION

HOARDERS AND TAX EVADERS BRANDED ANTI-SOCIAL

EMPHASIS ON INCREASED INDUSTRIAL AND AGRICULTURAL PRODUCTION

INDEPENDENCE DAY ADDRESS TO THE NATION

New Delhi, August 15, 1974
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Addressing the nation on the 27th anniversary of Independence, the Prime Minister, Shrimati Indira Gandhi, said here today that even though the country was confronted with grave economic crisis it had the capacity to emerge stronger from the ordeal.

Shrimati Gandhi said that the Government was determined to fight anti-social elements who indulged in private profiteering at the cost of community and invited every citizen to forge a united front to face the current challenge of shortages and high prices.

The Prime Minister said that instead of suffering from a sense of despondency and frustration, the country should sit up and find ways to get over the present difficulties.

Shrimati Gandhi appealed both to farmers and industrial workers to increase production in their respective fields and assured the nation that she saw a bright future for the country.

Following.....

Following is the free rendering of the Prime Minister's speech delivered in Hindi:

Citizens of India, I extend to you my greetings on this anniversary of our Independence. In their long history, the people of India have passed through many vicissitudes and undergone many sufferings but the economic problem which face us today envelops all of us. Thus, while we are happy on our Independence Day anniversary, my heart is full of sorrow and anxiety. I am aware of the difficulties you are facing. Floods and droughts have further added to the sufferings of the people already burdened with economic difficulty. My sympathies go out to you in your difficulties.

Of late, the burning question before us all has been one of rising prices and scarcity of essential commodities. You are also aware somewhat of the circumstances that have led the country to this situation. But it should not lead us to believe that nothing has been achieved during all these years. In essence, the progress that we have made and the crisis and challenges we have faced have contributed to our economic difficulties. At a time like this we should not be debating as to how and why these difficulties have arisen. Instead, we should be thinking of the ways to surmount these problems unitedly. In the past also the Indian people tackled many a crisis on war footing because they faced it unitedly and they could surmount it successfully.

Drought....

and stopping work, we have to find whether we can do with other things. Because of shortages even the affluent countries of the world are today falling back on old methods and techniques. They are adopting these methods also because of suitable blending of the old and new methods can have a better effect on our work.

When the application of chemical fertilisers came into vogue and the farmer saw that it increased production, so he took to extensive use of chemical fertilisers abandoning green manure and compost which he used to apply earlier. It is necessary that both chemical fertilisers as well as green manure etc. are applied not only to make up for the shortage of chemical fertilisers but also to maintain the strength of the soil itself.

Similarly, there are other shortages like that of power and the Government is making every effort to increase power generation. There is also shortage of petroleum. While we are exploring for oil, we have to find alternative sources of energy. Here again, we find that the western countries are reverting to many old practices which are being adopted not permanently but for the duration of scarcity. We too have to find ways to utilise wind-mill power and solar energy. These are vast sources of energy but we have also our own old method which we have to introduce in the name of Gobar gas plant. I am only giving you an illustration.

Invention is not something that is left to scientists alone. Today, everyone, whether he is a city dweller or lives in the village, has to constantly think of new ideas

and new....

money supply increases and if production is not proportionately increased it leads to serious consequences.

You are all aware of the unavoidable and essential expenditure the Government had to incur like giving relief to drought stricken people and meeting the cost of war. There have been other expenditure also from which it was difficult to escape and these have contributed to inflation. We are at the present engaged incontaining inflation and to some extent we have succeeded. If you would understand the issues involved and extend to us your cooperation, we would be able to succeed in greater measure and save the situation.

Our farmers have received considerable assistance and encouragement. It is often debated as to which should be encouraged more - agriculture or industry. In fact there is no conflict between the two and both agriculture as well as industry have to be encouraged. Our kisans feed the country. It is their hard work and their strength which has allowed the country to survive for centuries. The farmers, therefore have got to be helped so that production increases and the standard of rural development goes up. It is their duty to bring under cultivation every inch of land and every body should ensure that cultivable land is not wasted. There is shortage of fertilizers. The demand for chemical fertiliser has increased tremendously, but scarcity is not due to fall in production alone, it has occured also because the demand is much greater than ever before. Even the small farmer knows fertilisers and we are happy that he is prepared to change his traditional ways. But instead of rueing the short

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ties. There has been good progress in our agricultural production and you are aware that at times it has also doubled or trebled. However, in the last four years the rate of growth has not been the same as it was in the previous years. This year, particularly, shortage of fertilizers and quality seeds further added to the difficulties. Even so, the shortages are not of an extent as to make them unbearable. We may have to modify our habits, change traditional ways and we may have to also suffer a bit. Once we accept this, it would not be beyond us to bear with the situation. To believe that nothing is getting done or can be done, and to get utterly dismayed would be truly a dangerous thing. At a time like this all of us have some responsibilities to carry. The Government has the first responsibility and we are not shirking it.

You must have observed that in the last few days we have taken certain stringent steps to reduce the Government's expenditure. Many programmes, although beneficial to the people but not considered essential were abandoned. Every effort is being made to restrict Government's spending. There are many things which are in short supply and the Government is devoting its attention to reducing their consumption in order to conserve them for essential purposes. It was never our intention to freeze or reduce wages or dearness allowance. All that we want is that a part of it may be set aside and may not be spent. The money so deposited would also fetch attractive interest. When there is greater spending, the

money....

and new ways that may help us in our own work or may be beneficial to the community and the country.

Just as farmers have to increase agricultural production, industrial production too has to be increased because without industry many things of necessity including those needed by the farmers themselves, cannot be made available whether it is fertilisers or tractor or other equipment, because all these things are produced in big plants set up at the cost of crores of rupees. What we have to see is whether the farmers are in turn prepared to somewhat help the Government and the country. The rich farmers, who have greatly benefited from the new method should now offer their help so that the standard of rural life can be further raised. In this way they can help themselves. Greater the awareness among our villages, the more would be the production. With increased production, more necessities of life, of comfort and entertainment would become available in the villages.

Who suffers the burden of taxes when they are increased today? We regret that many big people are able to escape the taxation net. Some are not even listed as tax-payers. I can see in front of me the ancient Chandni Chowk. Other cities too must be having similar ancient and beautiful bazars. All businessmen are not bad but when a few of them do something wrong they bring bad name to the entire community. Those who do not pay the taxes or adulterate food articles and drugs or those who indulge in hoarding and blackmarketing, and amass black money, add to the sufferings of the country. That a few people should exploit the difficulties of the masses and for-

get about...

get about the country's future for the sake of individual gain is something which should be considered a blemish on th fair name of India.

It is not a question of the future of others alone; it is also a question of the future of their own children. When large number of persons evade payment of taxes - and these include both big and middle class people including contractors, lawyers, doctors and many self-employed persons, the entire burden of taxation devolves on fixed wage earners. They suffe in every way. It is often suggested that there should be a ceiling of land but then what are we doing about the urban areas. There are many rich people in the cities and we are looking into what can be done about them. Many measures have been adopted and taxes on them have been increased. Certain other measures are being examined to restrict their wealth. But we do see that the other city dwellers carry a tremendous burden and unless this burden is shared by all, the conditions in the country cannot improve.

I believe that the country depends as much on the work of farmers as the workers and managers in factories.

Both the urban and the rural populatio is dependent on them. The farmer and all others can be helped only when all workers and managers do their work properly, increase production and resolve their difficulties in one mann

Everyone in the world today is faced with difficulties or the other. They themselves have difficulties which have remained with us and would remain in future also in one form or the other. We have to face these difficulties unitedly.

We know...

We know that in times of bigger economic crisis, an affluent person, like an affluent nation has the greater capacity to survive and sustain itself. It is the poor who get crushed under economic burdens. India is a poor country compelled to carry a great burden but we are also conscious that although the Indian people may be poor, they have never allowed themselves to be crushed by any burden. We are conscious that we have carried many burdens in the past and have emerged stronger from the ordial.

What we have to consider is how we can rid the society of the evils pestering it. Can we remove these evils through violence? Can we remove them through agitations and by fighting amongst ourselves? The problems are so big that all together have to make an effort to solve them. The Government surely has a responsibility but every citizen can help in resolving difficulties. Our women can resolve that if something is not available in the open market or that it is available at a very high price, they would rather do without it or use something else in its place. Can't we do it? Our men and women can grow vegetables even in small cans if they have no land around their houses? They can help in keeping their city clean. They can help in the eradication of evil practices prevalent in their neighbourhood. They should think of extending help to those who need it. All this can be done by several citizens belonging to any class. ... ...

Even the poorest person can always do something which not only can help himself but can also be beneficial for all and source of strength to the country. Unfortunately, we feel over-exalted when something good happens; but when we face a crisis we feel utterly depressed so much so that one gets a feeling at times that the country is losing heart. No difficulties have ever got resolved by losing heart. I have already spelt out some of the reasons for the present scarcity conditions. There are other reasons too. One is that our population is fast increasing and the demand for every thing has risen sharply. Today, cycles, motor-cycles, tractors, transistors are common in the villages - something that could not be imagined a few years back. All this is good. But if we have to raise the standard of living in our villages and towns, we will have to control the rate of growth of our population. Every citizen must ponder over this and determine his duty.

Whatever difficulties we may have had to face, we always tried to see that we did not either abandon or relax our efforts to make the country stronger. Recently, as you might have observed, we exploded a nuclear device which boosted India's self-confidence. There were some mis-understandings, some mis-conceptions and we were criticised by some countries. Some others made it an excuse to malign us. We have declared that whatever power - nuclear or any other - India may have, it will be utilized for developmental purposes and for the benefit and progress of the people.

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On the international scene many new developments have taken place and new powers have emerged. India's effort has been to make friends with all. This friendship, you must have observed, has increased. The agreements we reached with our neighbouring countries to minimise tension and to strengthen friendship could be an example for the whole world. And yet, there is a country, a neighbouring country, who despite our efforts, has refused to learn from her past experience and continues even today to threaten us and some other neighbours. We do hope that peace will not be disturbed and all countries of this region, poor and developing countries as they are, will be able to apply themselves to resolving their economic and social problems and would not allow their attention to be diverted in any other direction. However, such is life that with all our difficulties, we cannot ignore external dangers and have to remain alert always.

Our country has emerged stronger in the past few years. In our long history the difficulties have always been there. You know of the difficulties we have had to face during the last few years. We had to fight wars; had to take care of millions of refugees sometimes coming from one side and sometimes from the other. But we have always moved forward and will continue to do so. All I can say say to you is that don't get discouraged on any account. Keep up your morale and have faith in the people and in the future of India.

The youth.../11-

The youth sometimes feel discontended and disturbed. this is natural. But in what manner must this discontentment and agitation express itself? Must they allow it to destroy one's strength or must it be utilised to build up that strength. More than us the youth need a strong and powerful India. The country also equally needs enthusiastic youngmen. We together have the task of extricating ourselves from our difficulties; our vision has to pierce through the darkness to be able to see the bright and beautiful future of India. We have also to realize that no country could carve out for itself a bright future without first countering difficulties and challenges. If we have to secure our future, we have to rapidly advance in a particular direction. We have to remove all impediments which weaken us - poverty, diversity, social evils or frustration - and we have to move forward.

In front of me here are a large number of children. When I see them, my thoughts go to millions of other children in our villages and cities. What sort of future shall we make for them? Our present age is a link between our glorious past and bright future. A great responsibility devolves on us. Let us all get together to carry out this responsibility. and realise for our children the hopes they have.

The respect that India commands today in the world is based on our actions and our policies. The policy of peace and friendship, the policy to make India strong and the policy to bring about equality and socialism -- these policies backed by the action are what have gained respect for India abroad.

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We have the responsibilities of furthering these policies. India is strong but not as much yet as she should be. She will be strong only when we are freed from frustration and find the courage to tell ourselves that we can surmount all difficulties, when we develop the confidence that we can achieve what we want to achieve. Whether we can do it or can't? You can answer it as well as I can. It all depends as much on every citizen as it does on me or on the Government.

I know that sometimes when very dark clouds gather, people tend to forget that there ever was sun or light. But the sun and the light are always there. They are there for him who has the vision to see, who is strong and has confidence. Such a person does not only see it but moves rapidly towards it, taking the country along with him. This is the lesson the day has for us because we are aware that the battle of independence was not won easily. It was won through sacrifice and the tri-colour of India was first unfurled on August 15 only after we had waded through frustration and gloomy days. This flag is not a mere piece of cloth ... dear to us. We hold it in great respect. Though a piece of cloth, the national flag of any country is honoured by that country. Its brave soldiers are always ready to lay down their lives to defend its honour. Why? Because the flag is a symbol of the hopes, the valour and the greatness of a country. That is why great respect is shown to this piece of cloth. But it is not by words alone that we may honour it. Nor do we honour it by just unfurling it. The real respect to it can be shown only by generating circumstances that would permit it to proudly flutter always. In war we keep the banner high but we have also...

also to ensure that nothing happens in the political, social and economic life of the nation that may tarnish its fair image either within or outside the country. Today we all have to consider and decide how we can always keep our flag high; how we will make our beloved country strong and in what way shall we ensure a bright future for our children and for our youth.

August 15 is a day of sacrifice, it is also, at the same time, a day to visualise the future. Unless there is mutual love, friendship and unity among all classes of our people,-- poor as well as rich, and among people of all faiths and different languages, nothing could be achieved. Casteism and communalism weaken us. While in some respects their influence has been neutralised, in some other directions it may have increased. If at times we can restrict these evils, why can't we eliminate them for ever? Why can't we uplift those who have always remained oppressed and to whom justice has always been denied?

Today I started my speech with the remark that my heart is full of sorrow and anxiety. But I want to tell you that we are not overwhelmed to the extent that we can not see our way or visualise our future. We are anxious and sad and we carry the burdens too. But with all that we see a bright future quite close and not far-off. We gradually move step by step to reach our goal. I hope all of you would move forward with the same sense of faith and self-confidence so that

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many of the evils and difficulties confronting us today are removed by the next August 15 and the country is ushered from darkness into light.

To all of you who are here before me in Delhi and all those who are perhaps hearing me on radio throughout the country, I again extend my greetings and good wishes for the future. I would repeat that all of us -- whether in uniform or not -- are soldiers of India. We should stand upright like soldiers and march forward with determination.

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